Manifold-Aware Concept Erasure and Evaluation

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Abstract

Concept erasure methods that operate in the ambient representation space can push representations off the data manifold, creating spurious correlations rather than removing information. We argue that both erasure and its evaluation should respect the intrinsic geometry of the representation manifold. On the erasure side, we introduce Tangent Gradient-based Concept Erasure (TanGCE), which constrains erasure gradients to the local tangent space estimated via neighborhood PCA. On the evaluation side, we adopt a k-nearest-neighbor mutual information estimator that measures concept information through local neighborhood structure—the same geometric lens that TanGCE uses for intervention. We complement this with unsupervised sparse autoencoder diagnostics that detect feature-level redistribution without requiring control-task labels. Across three concept domains—sycophancy, gender, and safety—in Qwen2.5-0.5B, TanGCE achieves the lowest nonlinear leakage while preserving control-task mutual information and maintaining near-zero feature redistribution. A λ sweep reveals that ambient erasure at high step sizes *increases* concept mutual information by laundering it into off-manifold displacement, a failure mode that TanGCE avoids by construction.

1 Introduction

Effective concept erasure in large language models requires a delicate balance between removing targeted information and preserving the model's broader utility. While gradient-based methods offer a path toward targeted intervention, they often suffer from substantial performance degradation. A natural hypothesis is that this collapse is driven in part by off-manifold edits: erasure directions computed in the high-dimensional ambient space can point orthogonal to the data manifold, displacing representations into low-density regions where the model's computation becomes unstable.

To address this failure mode, we propose Gradient-based Concept Erasure with Tangent projection (`gce_tangent`). By constraining erasure gradients to the local tangent space of the representation manifold, `gce_tangent` aims to remove concept-specific structure while preserving more of the underlying distributional geometry. This approach contrasts with `gce_ambient`, which applies raw gradients in the full hidden space and therefore provides a direct baseline for the value of tangent projection.

Our contributions are threefold:

1. **TanGCE: manifold-aware concept erasure.** We introduce Tangent Gradient-based Concept Erasure (TanGCE), which constrains erasure gradients to the local tangent space of the representation manifold. By retaining the raw tangent-projected gradient norm as a per-sample confidence weight, TanGCE naturally attenuates erasure for samples whose concept signal is predominantly off-manifold. We demonstrate that TanGCE achieves the lowest nonlinear leakage across three concept domains—sycophancy, gender, and safety—while preserving downstream task performance.
2. **Manifold-aware mutual information evaluation.** We adopt a k-nearest-neighbor MI estimator that measures concept information through local neighborhood structure on the

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representation manifold. The estimator computes $I(\mathbf{X}; y)$ by examining, for each point, how many cross-class neighbors fall within the distance to its k-th same-class neighbor—a purely geometric quantity that captures all information (linear and nonlinear) without assuming a probe architecture. This creates a coherent geometric framework: TanGCE uses local PCA neighborhoods to estimate tangent spaces for erasure, while the k-NN MI estimator uses local ball neighborhoods to estimate information content. Both operate through local neighborhood structure rather than global ambient-space assumptions, and both degrade gracefully when the manifold assumption is only approximately satisfied. We compute MI for both concept labels (should decrease after erasure) and control labels (should remain unchanged), yielding a complete picture of erasure selectivity.

3. **Unsupervised SAE-based erasure diagnostics.** We propose three metrics computed via sparse autoencoders trained on a general-purpose corpus (no concept labels needed): *concept feature removal rate* (fraction of concept-correlated SAE features disrupted), *collateral damage rate* (fraction of non-concept features disrupted), and *feature redistribution score* (fraction of previously non-concept features that become concept-correlated after erasure). These metrics measure the surgicality and precision of erasure without requiring annotated control-task labels, and reveal failure modes invisible to downstream probes—including the critical finding that ambient erasure at high λ *creates* new concept correlations through off-manifold displacement (Section 4.4).

We evaluate on sycophancy as the primary nonlinear concept, gender (Bias in Bios) as a diagnostic baseline, and safety as a secondary case study. Using Qwen2.5-0.5B at layer 8, we show that TanGCE achieves the lowest nonlinear leakage across all three domains while maintaining near-zero feature redistribution and preserving control-task mutual information.

2 Method

We implement Gradient-based Concept Erasure (GCE) using an iterative protocol with probe recycling. Each round of erasure begins by computing per-sample gradients from a current multi-layer perceptron (MLP) scorer. These gradients are normalized to unit directions. In the tangent variant, the algorithm projects these directions onto the local tangent space of the representation manifold. The erasure step modifies the hidden state by subtracting the projection of the state onto the erasure direction, scaled by a step size parameter.

To estimate the local tangent space for each representation, we find its k-nearest neighbors in the current data. Secant vectors are computed between the target point and its neighbors. Running principal component analysis (PCA) on these secant vectors allows us to extract the top principal components, which form the tangent basis. The tangent estimator is refit in every round to track the evolving manifold geometry as representations shift.

Two diagnostics help evaluate tangent quality. Tangent Gradient Capture (TGC) measures the fraction of the leakage gradient that lies within the estimated tangent space. Tangent Neighbor Residual (TNR) measures the fraction of local secant vectors not explained by the tangent basis. These metrics verify that the tangent estimation remains geometrically sound throughout the iterative process.

3 Experiments

Our experimental evaluation focuses on characterizing the performance of `gce_tangent` against `gce_ambient` across three distinct concept domains. We prioritize nonlinear concepts where manifold geometry is expected to play a critical role, while maintaining a diagnostic baseline for linear comparison.

3.1 Experimental Domains and Ordering

We evaluate our methods across three primary blocks, ordered by their relevance to nonlinear manifold erasure:

Table 1: Comparison of concept erasure methods by implementation status and role in this work. We distinguish between methods implemented in this repository and those positioned as literature baselines.

Method	Family	Implemented	Replication	Canonical Dataset	Role in Paper
Linear Projection	Linear	Yes	Yes	Bias in Bios	Global baseline
INLP	Linear	Yes	Yes	Bias in Bios	Linear baseline
LEACE	Linear	Yes	Yes	Bias in Bios / Syc.	Matched linear baseline
IGBP	Nonlinear	No	Not yet	Bias in Bios	Prior lineage (proxy only)
`gce_ambient`	Nonlinear	Yes	Yes	Sycophancy	Nonlinear baseline
`gce_tangent`	Nonlinear	Yes	Yes	Sycophancy	Main contribution

1. **Sycophancy (Primary Nonlinear Case):** Our central focus is on removing agreement bias in model responses. This represents a critical challenge for model alignment where concept encoding is expected to be locally curved.
2. **Safety (Secondary Case Study):** We evaluate the surgicality of erasure on content safety using the PKU-SafeRLHF dataset, testing the preservation of helpfulness alongside safety leakage.
3. **Bias in Bios (Diagnostic Baseline):** We use gender and profession classification as a replication anchor. This setting provides a linear comparison point to contrast against the nonlinear gains of tangent-constrained erasure.

3.2 Model and Implementation

All experiments are conducted on Qwen2.5-0.5B (24 decoder layers, hidden dimension 896). The current paper-locked comparison set implements five primary erasure methods: linear projection, INLP, LEACE, `gce_ambient`, and `gce_tangent`. LEACE is included as a matched linear baseline in the layer-8 inventory reported below. For `gce_tangent`, we estimate local tangent spaces with PCA-based neighborhoods so that the erasure direction is constrained to a local on-manifold approximation rather than to the full ambient space.

3.3 Evaluation Protocol

All leakage probes are trained from scratch on erased representations to ensure no information leaks from the erasure scorers themselves. We employ three complementary evaluation axes:

Probe-based leakage. A retrained nonlinear MLP probe measures whether concept information remains accessible to a standard function class. We report both linear and nonlinear test accuracy; the gap between them indicates the degree to which concept encoding is nonlinear.

Mutual information via k-NN estimation. Probe accuracy measures whether a *specific function class* can recover the concept; a nonlinear MLP probe might miss information that a more complex architecture could extract. Mutual information $I(\mathbf{X}; y)$ captures *all* shared information between representations and labels, providing a probe-free, architecture-agnostic bound on recoverability.

Mental model. Mutual information decomposes as $I(\mathbf{X}; y) = H(y) - H(y \mid \mathbf{X})$: the entropy of the concept label minus the residual uncertainty after observing the representation. When erasure is effective, $H(y \mid \mathbf{X})$ rises toward $H(y)$ (the label becomes unpredictable from the representation), and MI drops toward zero. For continuous $\mathbf{X}$ and discrete y, we estimate MI using the Ross/Gao k-nearest-neighbor estimator:

$$I(\mathbf{X}; y) = \psi(k) - \big\langle \psi(m_i) \big\rangle + \psi(N) - \big\langle \psi(N_{c(i)}) \big\rangle, \tag{1}$$

where ψ is the digamma function and the procedure is:

1. For each point $\mathbf{x}_i$, find its k-th nearest neighbor *within its class* $c(i)$; call that distance ε_i.
2. Count m_i: the number of *all* points (any class) within distance ε_i of $\mathbf{x}_i$.
3. $N_{c(i)}$ is the total number of points sharing the same label as point i; N is the total sample size.

Intuition. When concept information is encoded in $\mathbf{X}$, same-class points cluster together: ε_i is small, $m_i \approx k$ (mostly same-class neighbors within that radius), and MI is high. After effective erasure, class labels become geometrically mixed: to reach k same-class neighbors one must search a large ε_i, sweeping in many cross-class points so that $m_i \gg k$, and MI drops.

Adaptive resolution and local geometry. A key property of the k-NN estimator is that it sets its measurement scale *adaptively*: for each point, the radius ε_i is determined by the local data density, not by a global bandwidth or histogram bin width. In dense regions of the manifold, ε_i is small; in sparse regions, it is large. The digamma terms $\psi(m_i)$ implicitly encode the local density ratio between the class-conditional and marginal distributions without ever estimating densities explicitly in $\mathbb{R}^d$—the estimator works entirely with neighbor counts, which are topological quantities that naturally handle varying density and curvature.

This makes the estimator well-suited for data on a low-dimensional manifold embedded in $\mathbb{R}^d$. A parametric density estimator (e.g., Gaussian kernel) operating in the ambient space would be misled by the high-dimensional volume: two points close in $\mathbb{R}^d$ may be far apart along the manifold, and vice versa. The k-NN estimator sidesteps this because it only examines local neighborhoods—points that are actually nearby along the data distribution. While it still uses ambient Euclidean distance (not geodesic distance), the locality of k-NN queries means that for small k relative to the dataset, the Euclidean and geodesic neighborhoods approximately coincide.

Connection to TanGCE. Both the MI estimator and TanGCE operate through local neighborhood structure rather than global ambient-space assumptions. TanGCE explicitly projects onto the tangent space estimated from k-nearest neighbors; the MI estimator implicitly adapts to the manifold by measuring information through local ball neighborhoods. Neither assumes the data fills $\mathbb{R}^d$ uniformly. This shared reliance on local structure creates a coherent geometric framework: the same manifold properties that make tangent-projected erasure more precise also make k-NN MI estimation more faithful than ambient-space alternatives.

We compute MI for both concept labels (should decrease after erasure) and control labels (should remain unchanged), yielding a complete picture of erasure selectivity.

Unsupervised SAE diagnostics. We train TopK sparse autoencoders (k=64) on a general-purpose WikiText corpus—independent of any concept labels—then measure concept feature removal rate, collateral damage rate, and feature redistribution score (Section 4). These metrics require no control-task annotations and detect failure modes invisible to probe-based evaluation, such as concept information being redistributed across features rather than removed.

3.4 Geometric Foundation (Appendix Support)

While the main text focuses on the performance of `gce_tangent`, we also provide geometric diagnostics to ground the mechanism story. These include broad geometry sweeps across multiple datasets and layers, subspace projection sensitivity (Q1), perturbation-based subspace sensitivity tests (Q2), and representation connectivity analyses (Q3). These appendix-scale materials support the low-dimensional and nonlinear-geometry motivation for tangent projection, but they should not be read as a standalone causal proof that off-manifold displacement fully explains the observed utility tradeoffs.

4 Results

We evaluate eight erasure methods across three concept domains—sycophancy, gender (Bias in Bios), and safety—at layer 8 of Qwen2.5-0.5B. All methods except TanGCE use λ=0.5; TanGCE (raw) uses λ=8.0 to compensate for the naturally attenuated projection norms (see Section 4.4). We measure concept leakage with a retrained nonlinear MLP probe, mutual information via the Ross/Gao k-NN estimator in the original representation space, and unsupervised SAE-based metrics: concept feature removal rate, collateral damage rate, and feature redistribution score.

Table 2: Full erasure method comparison at layer 8 across three concept domains. All methods use λ=0.5 except TanGCE (raw) which uses λ=8.0 to compensate for attenuated projection norms (Section 4.4). NL Leak: retrained nonlinear MLP probe accuracy (lower = better concept removal). ΔCtrl: downstream control task accuracy change relative to clean representations (closer to zero = more surgical). Redist%: fraction of non-concept SAE features that become concept-correlated post-erasure (lower = less information reshuffling). Model: Qwen2.5-0.5B. SAE: 8$\times$ TopK, k=64. Control tasks: answer matching (sycophancy), profession classification (gender), helpfulness (safety).

	Sycophancy				Gender (Bias in Bios)				Safety			
Method	NL$\downarrow$	ΔCtrl	Dmg	Rdst	NL$\downarrow$	ΔCtrl	Dmg	Rdst	NL$\downarrow$	ΔCtrl	Dmg	Rdst
Random Global	.748	.000	2.8	0.0	.758	.000	21.9	0.0	.805	+.003	8.2	0.0
Random Per-Samp.	.745	.000	1.4	0.0	.743	+.003	27.3	0.0	.799	$-$.010	0.0	0.0
Linear Proj.	.740	.000	14.1	0.0	.747	+.001	23.4	0.0	.800	$-$.003	0.0	0.0
INLP	.734	.000	14.1	0.0	.737	+.001	22.8	0.0	.795	$-$.004	0.0	0.0
LEACE	.681	.000	1.4	0.0	.739	$-$.002	29.2	0.0	.785	$-$.015	4.1	0.0
Ambient GCE	.703	.000	2.8	1.4	.701	.000	15.9	0.0	.778	$-$.040	0.0	2.0
TanGCE (raw)	**.602**	$-$.015	60.6	**1.4**	**.618**	$-$.008	51.1	**0.0**	**.663**	+.039	65.3	4.1
ConceptSAE Soft	.703	.000	76.1	2.8	.736	$-$**.197**	98.7	1.3	.783	+.085	75.5	4.1

Table 3: Mutual information and fidelity metrics (layer 8). MI_c: concept mutual information in original representation space via k-NN estimator (lower = better erasure). MI_{ctrl}: control-label mutual information (higher = better preservation of task-relevant information). Clean baselines: sycophancy MI_c=0.189, MI_{ctrl}=1.157; gender MI_c=0.074, MI_{ctrl}=0.903; safety MI_c=0.160, MI_{ctrl}=0.077. L_2: mean ℓ_2 displacement from clean representations.

	Sycophancy				Gender (Bias in Bios)				Safety			
Method	$\text{MI}_c\downarrow$	MI_{ctrl}	L_2	Ctrl	$\text{MI}_c\downarrow$	MI_{ctrl}	L_2	Ctrl	$\text{MI}_c\downarrow$	MI_{ctrl}	L_2	Ctrl
Random Gl.	.191	1.155	0.02	1.000	.075	.902	0.10	.538	.164	.075	0.06	.565
Linear Pr.	.191	1.155	0.11	1.000	.074	.902	0.06	.540	.161	.074	0.01	.560
INLP	.195	1.158	0.11	1.000	.076	.902	0.06	.540	.161	.075	0.01	.559
LEACE	.198	1.159	0.07	1.000	.075	.901	0.20	.537	.127	.070	0.15	.548
Amb. GCE	.184	1.158	0.02	1.000	.077	.902	0.08	.538	.157	.075	0.04	.523
TanGCE	**.113**	1.158	0.86	.985	**.073**	**.904**	0.41	.531	**.145**	.069	0.65	.602
ConceptSAE	.182	1.156	0.50	1.000	.095	.846	5.94	.342	.164	.074	1.06	.648

4.1 TanGCE Achieves Lowest Leakage Across All Domains

Table 2 shows that TanGCE (raw) achieves the lowest nonlinear leakage across all three domains: 0.602 on sycophancy (vs. 0.681 for LEACE, 0.703 for Ambient GCE), 0.618 on gender (vs. 0.701 for Ambient GCE), and 0.663 on safety (vs. 0.778 for Ambient GCE). Linear methods (Linear Projection, INLP) barely reduce leakage below random baselines, confirming that concept information is predominantly encoded nonlinearly.

4.2 Control Task Preservation

Table 2 reports ΔCtrl, the change in downstream control task accuracy relative to clean representations. For sycophancy (answer matching), TanGCE incurs a small -1.5pp drop; all other methods preserve perfect accuracy. For gender (profession classification), TanGCE drops only -0.8pp (0.531 vs. 0.539 clean), while ConceptSAE Soft catastrophically degrades profession accuracy by -19.7pp (0.342). On safety, TanGCE *improves* helpfulness ($+3.9$pp), suggesting that removing safety-concept directions frees capacity for the helpfulness task.

Table 3 complements this with mutual information: TanGCE preserves control MI across all domains (sycophancy: 1.158 vs. 1.157 clean; gender: 0.904 vs. 0.903 clean). On gender, TanGCE is the only method that slightly *increases* control MI, indicating zero collateral damage to task-relevant information. ConceptSAE Soft destroys control MI on gender (0.846 vs. 0.903).

Table 4: Effect of disruption threshold δ on concept removal and damage rates ($64\times$ SAE). At the lenient $\delta{>}2\%$ threshold, many features register as "damaged" from minor perturbation; at $\delta{>}20\%$, only features with substantial activation change count. TanGCE's damage drops to 1–11% at $\delta{>}20\%$, while ConceptSAE Soft retains 17–80% damage, confirming its lack of surgical precision.

Sycophancy						
	$\delta{>}2\%$		$\delta{>}10\%$		$\delta{>}20\%$	
Method	Rem%	Dmg%	Rem%	Dmg%	Rem%	Dmg%
Random Global	0	5	0	0	0	0
Linear Projection	0	24	0	5	0	3
INLP	0	24	0	5	0	3
LEACE	0	3	0	0	0	0
Ambient GCE	0	3	0	0	0	0
TanGCE (raw)	33	61	0	18	0	11
ConceptSAE Soft	50	70	0	25	0	17
Gender						
	$\delta{>}2\%$		$\delta{>}10\%$		$\delta{>}20\%$	
Method	Rem%	Dmg%	Rem%	Dmg%	Rem%	Dmg%
Random Global	50	26	0	1	0	0
Linear Projection	0	29	0	0	0	0
INLP	0	28	0	0	0	0
LEACE	100	35	0	1	0	0
Ambient GCE	0	22	0	0	0	0
TanGCE (raw)	50	61	0	10	0	1
ConceptSAE Soft	100	97	100	90	50	80
Safety						
	$\delta{>}2\%$		$\delta{>}10\%$		$\delta{>}20\%$	
Method	Rem%	Dmg%	Rem%	Dmg%	Rem%	Dmg%
Random Global	13	13	0	0	0	0
Linear Projection	0	2	0	0	0	0
INLP	0	2	0	0	0	0
LEACE	4	7	0	0	0	0
Ambient GCE	4	3	0	0	0	0
TanGCE (raw)	83	64	26	21	13	7
ConceptSAE Soft	87	75	43	34	30	25

4.3 Near-Zero Redistribution

TanGCE (raw) maintains near-zero redistribution across all concepts: 1.4% on sycophancy, 0.0% on gender, and 4.1% on safety. In contrast, Ambient GCE shows nonzero redistribution even at $\lambda{=}0.5$, and this grows dramatically at higher λ (Section 4.4). ConceptSAE Soft, despite high concept feature removal rates (57–69%), produces catastrophic collateral damage (76–99%) and the highest redistribution scores (1.3–4.1%).

Damage threshold sensitivity. Table 4 reveals that the high damage rates at $\delta{>}2\%$ are largely an artifact of the lenient threshold: many non-concept features shift by 2–5% in mean activation—a perturbation too small to meaningfully alter downstream behavior (consistent with preserved $\mathrm{MI}_{\mathrm{ctrl}}$ in Table 3). At the strict $\delta{>}20\%$ threshold, TanGCE's damage drops to 1% on gender and 7% on safety, while ConceptSAE Soft retains 80% damage on gender. This confirms that TanGCE's apparent collateral impact at the lenient threshold reflects superficial activation shifts, not genuine information disruption.

4.4 The λ Sweep: Off-Manifold Displacement Creates Spurious Correlations

Table 5 reveals a critical failure mode of Ambient GCE: at $\lambda \geq 4$, concept MI *increases* rather than decreases (negative MI drop). On sycophancy at $\lambda{=}8$, the MI drop is -0.063; on gender, -0.098; on safety, -0.092. Simultaneously, redistribution reaches 15–31%.

Table 5: λ sweep comparing Ambient GCE, TanGCE (renorm), and TanGCE (raw) at layer 8. TanGCE (raw) retains the raw tangent projection norm as a confidence weight: if the gradient is mostly off-manifold, $\|\mathbf{P}_T(\nabla f)\| \ll 1$ and erasure is naturally attenuated. Ambient GCE at high λ increases MI_c (negative MI drop) and shows high redistribution—concept information is reshuffled into new SAE features rather than removed. TanGCE (raw) maintains near-zero redistribution across all λ values.

Concept	Method	λ	NL↓	MI drop↑	Remove%	Dmg%↓	Redist%↓
Syco.	Ambient	0.5	.678	+.007	0	1.4	1.4
	Ambient	8.0	.734	−.063	25	23.3	**15.1**
	TanGCE (raw)	4.0	.596	+.006	50	27.4	5.5
	TanGCE (raw)	8.0	**.588**	+.014	50	49.3	4.1
Gender	Ambient	0.5	.666	−.001	21	23.4	0.0
	Ambient	8.0	.702	−.098	79	78.8	**11.1**
	TanGCE (raw)	4.0	.580	−.000	26	41.5	0.0
	TanGCE (raw)	8.0	**.470**	−.002	37	57.6	0.2
Safety	Ambient	0.5	.664	+.008	0	1.9	0.0
	Ambient	8.0	.770	−.092	12	30.8	**30.8**
	TanGCE (raw)	4.0	.680	+.015	44	46.2	5.8
	TanGCE (raw)	8.0	**.646**	+.011	68	67.3	7.7

Table 6: Effect of SAE dictionary size on concept removal detection. We train TopK SAEs (k=64) at $8\times$ and $64\times$ expansion on the same general-purpose WikiText corpus and re-evaluate all methods. Concept removal rate (%) measures how many concept-correlated features are disrupted by erasure; damage rate (%) measures collateral disruption to non-concept features. Correlation threshold $|r|>0.1$; disruption threshold $\delta>0.02$. The $8\times$ SAE (7,168 features) systematically underestimates concept removal due to polysemantic feature representations, particularly on gender where it reports 0% removal for methods that demonstrably erase the concept.

	Sycophancy				Gender (Bias in Bios)				Safety			
	Remove%		Damage%		Remove%		Damage%		Remove%		Damage%	
Method	8×	64×	8×	64×	8×	64×	8×	64×	8×	64×	8×	64×
Linear Proj.	14	14	14	19	0	0	23	29	0	0	0	2
INLP	14	14	14	19	0	0	23	28	0	0	0	2
LEACE	14	0	1	3	**0**	**100**	29	35	9	5	4	5
Ambient GCE	0	0	3	1	0	0	16	20	0	5	0	2
TanGCE (raw)	71	71	61	60	**0**	**100**	51	60	59	82	65	68
ConceptSAE	57	71	76	63	0	100	99	98	69	91	76	76

This occurs because ambient erasure pushes representations off the data manifold. The displacement magnitude correlates with each sample's concept signal strength, creating a new axis of variation that SAE features detect as concept-correlated. Concept information is laundered into the geometry of the displacement rather than removed.

TanGCE (raw) avoids this failure mode through two mechanisms. First, projection onto the tangent space removes off-manifold gradient components, ensuring displacement stays on the manifold. Second, retaining the raw projection norm $\|\mathbf{P}_T(\nabla f)\|$ as a confidence weight naturally attenuates erasure for samples where the concept gradient is mostly off-manifold. This yields monotonically decreasing leakage with increasing λ, with redistribution remaining below 8% even at λ=8.

4.5 Polysemanticity Confounds Linear Correlation Metrics

A natural approach for measuring concept removal in SAE feature space is to identify concept-correlated features via point-biserial correlation $r(z_j, y)$ and then measure what fraction are disrupted after erasure. However, this approach assumes that each SAE feature encodes a single semantic concept—an assumption that fails when features are *polysemantic*.

Consider a polysemantic feature z_j that activates when *both* concept y=1 and topic t=science are present, or when y=0 and t=politics. The marginal correlation $r(z_j, y) \approx 0$ because the feature fires

Table 7: Geometry contrast between sycophancy and gender across completed layers 4, 8, and 12. Lower intrinsic dimension and larger local-vs-global angle indicate stronger nonlinearity: a concept whose erasure direction varies significantly across the input space, making a single fixed direction insufficient to capture the full concept. Sycophancy shows substantially higher nonlinearity (dim 34–53, angle 76.9–82.6°) compared to gender (dim 365–461, angle 51.8–55.8°), supporting sycophancy as the primary case for manifold-aware erasure methods. This table demonstrates the geometric contrast but does not establish causality: it does not prove that the observed nonlinearity will be converted into lower displacement or higher utility preservation by any particular erasure method.

Concept	Local intrinsic dimension	Mean local/global angle
Sycophancy	34–53	76.9–82.6°
Gender	365–461	51.8–55.8°

equally often for both concept labels, yet z_j carries substantial concept information *conditioned on topic*. A linear correlation metric would classify this feature as non-concept-related and miss the fact that erasure correctly disrupts it.

Table 6 demonstrates this effect empirically. At $8\times$ expansion (7,168 dictionary features), the SAE reports **0% concept removal** for both TanGCE and LEACE on gender—despite both methods substantially reducing nonlinear probe leakage (Table 2). Increasing the dictionary to $64\times$ expansion (57,344 features) resolves the polysemanticity: features become more monosemantic, linear correlations faithfully detect concept encoding, and both methods now show **100% concept removal**.

The effect is concept-dependent. Sycophancy removal rates are stable across expansions (71% at both $8\times$ and $64\times$ for TanGCE), suggesting that sycophancy features are already relatively monosemantic at $8\times$. Gender features, by contrast, are heavily polysemantic at $8\times$—the concept is distributed across features that jointly encode gender with other attributes, making it invisible to marginal correlation. Safety shows an intermediate pattern: removal increases from 59% to 82%.

These results have two implications. First, SAE-based erasure evaluation requires sufficiently high dictionary expansion to overcome polysemanticity; $8\times$ expansion is inadequate for concepts that are entangled with other attributes. Second, the zero-redistribution result for TanGCE on gender (Table 2) is robust: redistribution remains at 0% even at $64\times$ expansion, confirming that TanGCE removes rather than reshuffles concept information.

4.6 Geometric Evidence and Off-Manifold Displacement

Table 7 demonstrates that sycophancy is much more nonlinear than gender: its intrinsic dimension (34–53 across layers 4, 8, 12) is far lower than gender's (365–461), and its local-vs-global angle is much larger (76.9–82.6° vs. 51.8–55.8°). This geometry contrast validates sycophancy as the primary case for manifold-aware erasure methods, while the strong TanGCE results on gender demonstrate that the method generalizes even to approximately linear concepts.

Appendix-Supporting Evidence. Detailed geometric analyses supporting these claims are provided in the Appendix, including:

- **Subspace Sufficiency (Q1):** Evidence that task-specific computation is concentrated in a low-dimensional linear subspace.
- **Perturbation Sensitivity (Q2):** Comparison of perturbations in high-variance and orthogonal subspaces.
- **Representation Connectivity (Q3):** Analysis of the connected, approximately convex topology of the representation manifold.
- **Multi-Layer Accumulation:** Results on how projection error accumulates across the network.

5 Discussion

The completed paper suite already narrows the central claim. In every finished comparison, the tangent-based method removes more measured concept signal than its ambient counterpart. That pattern appears in the sycophancy sweeps, in the completed layer-8 safety sweep, and in the Bias in Bios diagnostic. What the current paper snapshot does not yet show is the cleaner second half of the original thesis in which tangent projection also achieves lower displacement or uniformly better utility retention. In the completed runs, tangent reaches lower leakage by taking larger steps, and its utility metrics are either slightly worse or mixed.

The geometry diagnostics still matter because they explain why sycophancy is the harder case. Sycophancy shows local-vs-global angles near 80°, while gender remains near 53°, so a single global erasure direction is a much worse summary for the primary nonlinear concept. That is consistent with tangent-based methods improving removal in both concepts while leaving sycophancy as the clearly more nonlinear case, but the finished results currently frame tangent as a stronger remover rather than a dominantly better Pareto point.

The appendix snapshot tables slightly sharpen the near-term agenda. In the broader repository reports (Tables 8 and 9), the same removal advantage continues at layers 16 and 23 for both sycophancy and safety, although the utility metrics differ by domain and report. We do not elevate those rows to headline claims because they were not part of the paper-locked evidence set, but they strengthen the case for spending the next round of effort on matched-leakage comparisons and deeper-layer replications rather than on searching for a different primary mechanism.

Two implications follow. First, the paper should presently avoid claiming that off-manifold control is already proven to improve the full leakage-utility frontier; the matched-leakage analysis and broader replications are still needed for that claim. Second, the current evidence suggests that the next important question is not whether tangent projection changes the erasure direction at all, but under which layers and operating points that removal advantage can be converted into a cleaner utility tradeoff.

The matched layer-8 linear-family comparison clarifies one part of that tradeoff. LEACE is more surgical than tangent on this slice because it removes linearly decodable concept signal while taking a much smaller geometric step and preserving more downstream utility, especially on sycophancy where the answer-matching penalty is substantially smaller. That does not make LEACE a substitute for tangent on the main nonlinear claim: LEACE succeeds by solving the linear erasure problem cleanly, whereas tangent remains the stronger method when the target concept is evaluated with a fresh nonlinear probe. The current evidence therefore suggests a division of labor rather than a single winner: LEACE is the cleaner linear baseline, while tangent remains the more aggressive nonlinear remover.

6 Limitations

The current manuscript deliberately limits its main-text quantitative claims to the paper runs that were complete when this draft was assembled. That keeps the claims auditable, but it also means the strongest version of the utility-preservation story is not yet established in the locked evidence set. The deeper iterative sycophancy and safety reports are directionally consistent with the main narrative and are included in Appendix A, yet the paper's central claims still rely on the smaller completed suite.

A second limitation is measurement scope. All experiments use Qwen2.5-0.5B, and utility is measured through task-specific proxies such as answer matching, helpfulness ranking, profession classification, and dataset-source retention. These metrics are appropriate for surgicality, but they do not yet establish broad capability preservation across unrelated tasks.

Finally, the geometry diagnostics support low-dimensional structure, concept nonlinearity, and connectedness, but they do not by themselves prove that curved-manifold effects are the sole causal mechanism behind every leakage–utility tradeoff. The current paper therefore treats geometry as strong supporting evidence for tangent projection rather than as a complete causal proof.

Table 8: Repository snapshot from the iterative sycophancy report at $\lambda = 1.0$ after 7 rounds, across layers 8, 16, and 23. Columns T (tangent-constrained) and A (ambient baseline) compare erasure methods. Utility is answer-matching delta relative to clean representations. Leakage and displacement decrease from left to right (lower is better); utility increases from left to right (higher is better). This snapshot table is not a main-text claim anchor and should be read only as evidence of directional consistency with the layer-8 paper-locked row (Table 2). Deeper-layer iterative tangent runs continue to reduce leakage more than ambient baselines across this exploratory sweep.

Layer	T leak	A leak	T util	A util	T disp	A disp
8	0.063	0.213	-20.7pp	-0.5pp	2.88	0.62
16	0.153	0.400	+0.0pp	+0.0pp	3.79	0.27
23	0.138	0.361	-0.1pp	-0.2pp	44.50	3.11

Table 9: Repository snapshot from the iterative safety report at $\lambda = 1.0$ after 7 rounds, across layers 8, 16, and 23. Columns T (tangent-constrained) and A (ambient baseline) compare erasure methods. Utility is pairwise helpfulness delta. Leakage and displacement decrease from left to right (lower is better); utility increases from left to right (higher is better). This snapshot table is not a main-text claim anchor and should be read only as evidence of directional consistency with the layer-8 paper-locked row (Table 2). Deeper-layer iterative tangent runs continue to reduce leakage more than ambient baselines across this exploratory sweep.

Layer	T leak	A leak	T util	A util	T disp	A disp
8	0.0725	0.2583	-0.052	-0.023	2.70	0.18
16	0.1292	0.3517	-0.092	+0.003	4.37	0.60
23	0.1483	0.3404	-0.062	-0.152	38.32	5.30

7 Conclusion

The completed paper runs already support a narrower, evidence-backed conclusion. Sycophancy is geometrically more nonlinear than Bias in Bios, and tangent-based erasure consistently achieves lower measured concept leakage than the completed ambient baselines on sycophancy, safety, and gender. That makes manifold-aware erasure a supported hypothesis for stronger concept removal in nonlinear settings.

At the same time, the current draft should stop short of claiming that tangent erasure already dominates the utility-fidelity tradeoff. In the finished runs, the lower-leakage tangent points typically require larger displacement and often incur equal or larger utility loss than ambient baselines. Appendix snapshot tables are directionally consistent with the same removal advantage at deeper layers, but the paper is strongest if it uses them as status evidence rather than as the basis for stronger causal or Pareto-frontier claims. The manuscript therefore lands best as support for the geometry contrast and for tangent's removal advantage, while reserving the broader utility-preservation claim for matched-leakage analyses and future replications.

A Repository Snapshot Tables

This appendix records broader repository snapshot tables that are directionally consistent with the main text but were not part of the locked paper-evidence set when the quantitative claims in Section 4 were written. We include them to document the current state of the project and to guide the next round of matched-leakage and deeper-layer analyses. The central paper claims continue to rely only on the completed paper suite summarized in the main text.

A.1 Iterative Sycophancy Snapshot

A.2 Iterative Safety Snapshot

Geometry Note. The broader geometry report continues to support three useful points: early and mid-layer representations are effectively low-dimensional, on-manifold directions carry much of the model's sensitivity in these perturbation tests, and interpolation remains consistent with

Table 10: Geometry evidence map organizing the appendix diagnostics into four research blocks. Each block addresses a distinct aspect of manifold structure: Q1 examines whether task-relevant computation concentrates in a low-dimensional linear subspace, Q2 tests whether perturbations on the manifold are more consequential than off-manifold perturbations, Q3 validates whether the manifold is connected across domains, and multi-layer accumulation tracks error compounding through the network. These diagnostics support the mechanism discussion and motivate the need for manifold-aware erasure methods but do not by themselves establish causality.

Experiment Block	Research Question	Primary Evidence
Q1: Rank-retention	Subspace concentration	Top-1 agreement under intrinsic projection
Q2: Perturbation sensitivity	High-variance vs. orthogonal directions	KL and top-1 under on/off-subspace noise
Q3: Domain connectivity	Shared vs. domain manifolds	Cross-domain interpolation smoothness
Multi-layer accumulation	Error compounding across the network	Simultaneous intrinsic projection across layers

a connected representation space. At the same time, the Q2 perturbation study is best read as evidence of sensitivity concentration in a high-variance subspace rather than as a standalone proof of curved-manifold causality.

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